TRISTA

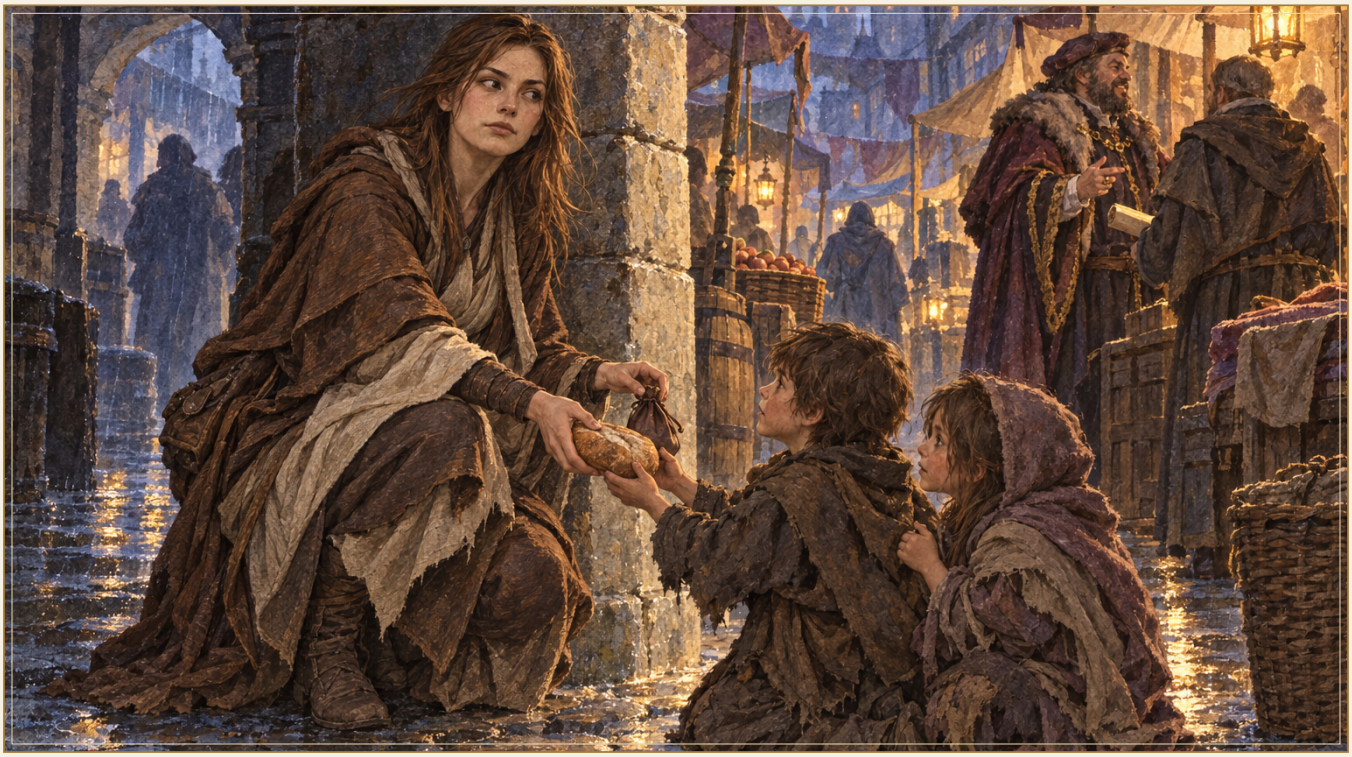
THE QUIET HAND

A character of The Echo Below

A monk, a watcher, and a debt remembered.

The Quiet Hand

Street thief - watcher - spy



She learned early that quiet people hear what louder folk miss.

Trista learned young that people rarely remember the quiet person in the room - until something goes missing.

She grew up around smugglers, messengers, card players, and informants. She learned to remember where a key was set down, notice an unlocked window from across a street, and read a room before anyone thought to watch her. Those talents made her useful as a courier and spy, and very good at slipping away unseen.

Wealth itself never interested her as much as what it revealed. Food vanished from merchants who cheated their customers. Coin left the purses of cruel landlords and appeared where hungry families would find it. Trista called that balance. She also knew, if she was honest, that she liked the challenge - and that an expensive unattended object could command her attention far too easily.

THE PRICE OF A MISTAKE

A Theft Too Costly

One prize was worth more trouble than any purse could repay.

Trista's rules made sense until the night she opened the wrong strongbox. Inside was a sealed ledger - the sort of small, ordinary thing that becomes priceless when it can ruin a powerful person. She took it believing she had found proof of corruption. She discovered too late that several dangerous people believed it belonged to them.

They did not simply ask for it back. They named a debt beyond anything she could steal or earn, then made it clear the sum was only an excuse. They wanted obedience. They wanted an example. For the first time, every exit Trista could find led to another locked door.

She kept her face calm. Inside, she understood that cleverness alone would not save her.

Someone Willing to Bet

Gundren paid the debt - and asked for nothing but a better choice.

Gundren Rockseeker intervened before Trista learned what her captors intended. He was not a magistrate, a hero from a ballad, or even someone she knew well. He was a practical dwarf with enough coin, nerve, and stubborn decency to make the problem disappear.

When Trista demanded to know why he would spend so much on a thief, Gundren answered as though the matter were obvious:

> ***"Everyone deserves at least one person willing to bet on them."***

He never demanded that she become someone else. He simply left her with a choice about what to do next. Trista has never forgotten the difference. To others, helping Gundren may be an adventure. To her, it is the repayment of a kindness no purse could measure.

Discipline, Not Erasure

Discipline did not erase her old talents. It gave them purpose.

Trista left much of her old criminal life behind and sought the discipline of a monastery. Breath, balance, repetition, and restraint gave names to instincts she had once trusted blindly. Her old talents remained: the quick hands, the watchful eyes, the sense for hiding places and lies. They simply began serving a different purpose.

The enormous robes she wears now hide the movement of an exceptionally quick fighter - and, conveniently, more than a few pockets. She has become something between monk, spy, thief, and wandering do-gooder.

The rules she keeps

1. Do not steal from people who cannot afford the loss.
2. Do not hurt someone when another answer exists.
3. Protect those who cannot protect themselves.
4. Never forget a debt.

The Unfinished Mark

A player-safe beginning

There is one mystery Gundren meant to place before Trista.

During his research, Gundren acquired a black stone medallion carved with one central circle and eight smaller circles. He did not understand it, but he intended to ask Trista for help. Whether she recovers it, accepts it, or entrusts it to someone else will happen in play.

The campaign begins near Phandalin, where Trista is helping escort supplies for Gundren. When that simple job turns dangerous, she will not walk away. Later, Waterdeep may become home: a city of rain, lanterns, old secrets, tempting valuables, and people worth returning to.

Trista does not begin with answers about the mark. She only knows Gundren trusted her judgment - and she intends to find him.

Gundren's sketch shows one circle at its heart and eight around it.

Playing Trista

PERSONALITY

Calm under pressure. She enters a room by noting exits, valuables, lies, and who looks afraid.

IDEAL

Power carries responsibility. Fortune built by crushing others should be used to relieve suffering.

BOND

Gundren bet on her when no one else would. She will not abandon him when he needs that faith returned.

FLAW

Valuable unattended objects test her self-control; curiosity can sound remarkably like permission.